A Matter of Resistance

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/45681355.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F, F/M

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Angella (She-Ra), Norwyn (She-Ra), Micah (She-Ra), George (She-Ra), He-Man | Adam

Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe - Medieval, Epilogue, Prequel, Yes It is Both an Epilogue and a Prequel Bite Me, Glimbow Content, prince catra, Knight Adora, Pre-Marriage Catradora, Glimbow Wedding, Fluff, Fluff and Angst, Pining, Mutual Pining, Requited Love, Glimmer is in love with Bow, Bow is in love with Glimmer, Adora is in Love with Catra (She-Ra), catra is in love with adora, POV Glimmer (She-Ra), Catra & Glimmer Friendship (She-Ra), Regents, Established Relationship, Love Confessions

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Part 2 of The Crown Demands But the Heart Desires Medieval AU

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by ResFlower

Summary

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Bow's eyes look like they might big out of his head. "Oh." He finally said quietly. "I didn't realize you had feelings for someone." He said softly.

She rolled her eyes. How dense could he possibly be? "It's not just someone. It's you, Bow."

OR

"Adora has been my guard for over a year now." Glimmer said cautiously still staring between the two, unclear what was happening.

Nothing could prepare the group for how the prince flushed in return, and then a stuttering purr rolled from deep in her. Her eyes widen and she looked around as if looking for some other purring magicat, before forcing it down by clearing her throat. It was of no use. When Catra's eyes came back onto Adora staring softly at her, the purr roared back to life.

OR

Before and after the event of The Crown Demand But the Heart Desires in Glimmer's POV. Can be read without the original, but I think it will read a lot better with it.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

"Glimmer, we have a surprise for you." Angella places a hand on her daughter's shoulder.

She turns to look at her parents. "What is it?" She wondered. Sometimes they would bring her treats when they visited other kingdoms, but neither regent had traveled recently.

"You have to come with us to the throne room to get it," Micah explained with a doting smile.

There in the middle of the throne room were her tutor and a kid. Glimmer couldn't help the little sigh she lets out. "More studies?" She asked with a tilt of her head. Her parents made it seem like it was something to be excited about, not another lecture from George. She'd have to explain privately what things were worth calling a surprise. Adults were so strange.

Angella laughed, shaking her head. Micah wrapped an arm around her waist. "No Glimmer, it isn't that. We thought it would be good for you to have a friend your age." Micah explained, shifting his gaze to the boy at George's side.

Glimmer looked at him too. She eyed the boy. He had curly brown hair and beautiful big brown eyes. A gentle smile that seemed genuine. Now that everyone turned to stare at him, he seemed a bit nervous.

She smiled at him, hoping it might make him feel better. He smiled back. She'd never really had a friend before—the only other kids who wanted to play with her were the royals who visited from other kingdoms and that was short-lived now that something bad was happening. Her mother and father wouldn't tell her what, but she knew they were worried.

"Your majesty, this is Bow. He's my son and we thought it might be nice for both of you if Bow takes his lessons here with you during the day and then leaves with me to go home." Goerge suggested.

“Could we play together?” Glimmer asked curiously. It would be nice to have a partner in lessons but someone to play with would really be something.

“Yes, That’s the idea, little love.” Micah said.

“Now?” She said brightly, looking up at her father.

He sighed, rolling his eyes fondly. “I guess it can’t hurt for you to get to know each other better before your lessons start. Run along now.”

She looked at Bow and nodded for him to follow her. She led him to a garden not far from the throne room, then she turned around and looked at him. He stood stalk still, looking more guard than boy.

"Your majesty." He said in an overly formal tone that sounded forced.

"You can call me Glimmer when it's just us." She said. She'd always wanted a friend.

He smiled softly with a whispered, "okay, Glimmer."

"Do you like to go horseback riding?" She asked eagerly.

He frowned. "I haven't learned how yet." He mumbled bashfully. “We don’t have horses at home.”

"That's okay! I'll teach you!" She never got to teach other people things. Everyone was always trying to teach her—to be a ruler, to have decorum, and to know the ways of her people. With Bow, she could just be herself. She grinned widely. "We’re going to be great friends." She decided then and there.

He nodded. “I’d like that.” She grabbed his hand and they ran off the barn to let the horses.

"Hey, Glim! What are you doing over there?" Bow called out loudly, startling her.

"N-nothing!" She stuttered out shoving her book out of sight. "Why would I be doing something?"

He looked at her oddly as if trying to solve a puzzle. "You okay?" He checked in. His voice dropped low last year and since then, Glimmer had known no peace. She ignored the shivers his voice gave her and answered with a noncommittal grunt, hoping it would make him go away. She should have known better. "You know you can tell me anything right?"

“Of course Bow! I was looking for something.” She lied.

Hi smiled brightly, his shoulder relaxing. “I can help you look! What are you looking for?”

She should have seen that coming. Lying to Bow was just difficult for her and she’d been keeping a huge secret from him for months now.

She sighed, flustered and caught. She decided to come clean. “I’m actually not looking for anything.” She admitted.

“Then what are you doing, Glimmer?”

“I was reading this.” She slid the book over to him. It was a book on the art of courtship and wooing. She had to sneak into the restricted area of the library to get it.

“Is there someone trying to woo you?” There’s a tightness in his eyes that Glimmer didn’t really understand.

“No, no. I’m—contemplating wooing someone.” She offered lamely.

Bow’s eyes look like they might big out of his head. “Oh.” He finally said quietly. “I didn’t realize you had feelings for someone.” He said softly.

She rolled her eyes. How dense could he possibly be? “It’s not just someone. It’s you, Bow.” She didn’t let him respond, instead pushing forward. “You’re my best friend first and I don’t want to make you uncomfortable. You can say the word and we can just forget—”

She stopped when she felt warm hands on her own. Bow looked at her so softly as he held her hands, his thumb rubbing the back of it in soothing circles. “Princess, I have feelings for you too.”

“Really?” She gaped. Bow had grown to be so gorgeous and kind, she never really contemplated it would be easy to capture his attention.

“Of course, Glimmer. You’re not just my best friend, you’re my closest confidante, and you’re such an amazing person. I simply don’t have the strength to resist.” He bit his lip. “I hadn’t said anything because *I* didn’t want to make you uncomfortable.” He sighed. "Besides, you know what the council thinks of our friendship, never mind anything more.” He added, anger clouding his face.

She groaned at the thought of Bright Moon’s council, especially Norwyn who has taken to giving Bow dirty looks whenever he sees him. With their studies completed Angella had granted Bow employment as a junior advisor and the council had not been thrilled.

“Who cares what all those old men think?”

Bow had been there for her through everything, the loss of her father, every turn in the war, and now even in meetings. But he was also there to make her life better, bring joy to it, and her knew her and made her feel safe. She wasn’t going to lose exploring that because of silly customs and traditions.

Bow stared at her tenderly. “Are you sure Glim? If we cross that line, there might not be any returning to what was there before.”

“I only want to return to you. Always.” She knew she was young, but she’d already known Bow for so long. She knew what love looked like because she’d seen it with her parents, and now she knew she had it with Bow.

He reached up and softly touched her cheek. “As you wish, princess.” He leaned down slowly placing a chaste kiss on her lips. She knew then and there that she’d made the right decision.

"Mom, let's say that I was to want to marry someone, but they are different." Weekly tea with her mother was sad but healing in a way. They used to have it with her father as well—carrying the tradition was a quiet but important comfort since he was lost to them.

"Different how dearest?" Angella inquired as she poured another cup and then passed her the sugar.

Glimmer stared into her tea leaves as if they could help her navigate the uncertain conversation. "They aren't royal." She finally admitted.

Her mother looked unsurprised. "You mean like Bow?" Queen Angella raised an eyebrow.

Glimmer gaped. "How did you—"

"Glimmer, you haven't exactly been subtle in your infatuation." She sighed and eyed her daughter. "The guards have seen Bow leaving your bedroom."

"Mom!" They’d been so careful she really hadn’t thought they’d been caught.

Angella rolled her eyes. "If you didn't want him to be spotted you should have escorted him out the window." She said matter of factly.

"*Mom*!" She'd rather be anywhere in the world than having this conversation.

"What? It's true!" Angella leans forward and started whispering conspiratorially. "I was young once too, you know. Your father and I—"

"Please no, mom!" Glimmer all but begged not interested in whatever direction that was going in. She sighed, hands covering her eyes in embarrassment. "It is about Bow though. I want to be prepared." She needed to know what path was available to them. She needed to know that she could love Bow fully knowing her mother would support her.

"You're too young to be thinking of marriage seriously." Angela hedged as she put her tea down.

"I mean, yes but"—she blushed her cheeks hot to the touch —"mom, I think he's it."

"Glimmer." She said her daughter's name with a helpless sigh. "You know the answer to that question. You've studied the laws that uphold Bright Moon."

"But the laws are stupid." She said beseechingly.

Angella sighed her expression clouded over. "I know that. If it were up to me, you know I would not restrict you in this way but —"

She shook her head. "The Bright Moon council is the only one that can change the laws and Norwyn has a stick up his butt." She sighed tiredly.

Angella fought a smile playing on the edge of her lips. "You said it, not me." Her face grew morose. "I wish I could do something, Glimmer, but it's out of my hands." She stared helplessly as Glimmer walked towards the door.

"It's fine. I understand." She said curtly before walking out, feeling more hopeless than ever. She wouldn't give up on Bow, however. They would just have to find another way.

"I'm assigning you a personal guard," Angella announced.

"What? No, I refuse." She said eyes flashing.

"Glimmer, you are beyond of age to have a personal guard. Soon you'll be taking on more responsibilities and you are the heir to the throne. You have to become acquainted with carrying security. I've given you all the freedom I've been able." She explained, her voice made of stone.

"The council is pushing this." Glimmer accused.

"They are. And I'm in agreement."

"Mother, why? Is this about—" She cut off. They both knew what the elephant in the room was when it came to Glimmer and the council.

"No. They insisted that you have a guard and I insisted on choosing. Someone loyal to the crown who would never report back to the council. Also someone I think you'd rather like if you gave her a chance."

"Her?" She'd assumed she'd have some old man creeping after her.

"Yes. She's incredibly talented at what she does. I trust her to keep you safe. And I trust her to be *discrete*." Angella gave her a meaningful look.

The fight left her at that. Her mother was constantly battling for these small concessions to protect her privacy. It didn't make the situation less frustrating. She and Bow had been together for over two years now, she knew where she belonged.

“Fine, I’ll meet her.” She conceded. If she had to have a guard, she supposed that one that was in her corner was better than one that reported to the council.

“Great, because she’s here.” Glimmer shot her an exasperated look but stayed silent. Angella knocked on the outer door twice and in came a tall blonde standing to attention. Glimmer’s first thought taking her in was that she looked very serious, a focused expression on her face. “Glimmer, this is Adora. She’ll be in charge of your security from here on out.”

The blonde immediately dropped into a low bow. “Your majesty. It’s an honor to serve you. I promise I will do my utmost to keep you safe and meet my duty.”

“Very nice to meet you, Adora.” Glimmer said diplomatically. “What do you consider to be your duty?”

Adora looked surprised by the question but seemed to answer honestly. “To keep you safe and protected at all times.”

“And what of more than my physical safety?” She probed while looking up at the guard.

She bit her lip, thinking deeply. “I think your safety includes protecting things like your privacy and your honor. I only wish the best for my regent.”

It was a good enough answer, Glimmer supposed. “And who do you swear your oath of fealty to?”

“I have a duty to Queen Angella but foremost to you, Princess Glimmer. I hope you place your trust in me and are not disappointed.”

“I have one last inquiry.” Adora nodded her head, braced for impact as if Glimmer might actually hit her. “Tell me one thing about yourself.”

Glimmer smiled at the confused expression on the blonde’s face. Her shoulders relaxed a bit as she mulled the question. “I have a twin brother, Adam. He’s actually a guard too! You might have seen him, he’s in the outdoor perimeter a lot of times. The guards try to keep us on different rotations because we look too alike. Adam says it’s because we get into too much trouble but you can’t believe a word he says.” The blonde was animated now, using her hands, and letting a small laugh slip through as she talked about her family.

Glimmer could see why her mother thought she might like her. “I look forward to spending time with you Adora.”

"So, what do you want to do tomorrow?" Bows eyes shone bright with excitement.

She couldn't help the dopey look that crossed her face when she looked at him. Here, with just him and Adora, she didn't have to mask how she felt.

"We can do whatever you want." Glimmer allowed. She loved days like this when they were free of the trappings that usually prevented them from seeing each other.

"Within the established safety protocols," Adora said, pointedly staring at Glimmer.

Glimmer sighed. Although she knew Adora was her guard first, she considered her to be her closest confidant, after Bow.

"Yeah yeah, safety." She rolled her eyes. Adora could be such a stick in the mud about things like that, which was odd because she could be so silly at other times.

"I say we go horseback riding out by the lake.” Bow proposed. “It’s secluded and it’s beautiful.”

“You start kissing and I will take all the horses and leave you behind.” Adora threatened, although her lips twitched, giving away

her lie.

“Did I hear someone say kissing?” Adam said loudly from his post. Glimmer and Bow laughed when Adora punched his shoulder, making him groan aloud. Adora was always at her wildest when her twin brother came into the picture.

“Stay quiet. Why do you always have to be the dumber twin.” Adora scolded while looking around to make sure no one heard.

“It’s because I’m too busy being the handsome twin to be the smart twin too.” Adam tossed back with a grin. Adora all but tackled him to the ground, making him laugh as they wrestled.

“Hey, twiddle dumb and twiddle dumber, you both have jobs don’t you?” Glimmer asked with a raised eyebrow.

The blondes froze and then quickly got to their feet standing to attention in front of the princess. “Sorry, Princess Glimmer,” Adam said with a rare blush on his cheeks.

She waved him off. “I don’t mind, it’s always nice when Adora is less serious. But we do have to leave.”

Adora nodded. She pushed Adam’s shoulder for good measure. “You’re twiddle dumber.” She ruffled the hair on his head and then walked off, a triumphant expression on her face.

Bow laughed as Adora walked behind them again, the picture-perfect guard once more. “I love my brothers, but I’ve never fought with them like that before.”

“It’s not real fighting! I love Adam to death. I don’t know who I’d be without him.” She explained as she seemed to move again into a more serious version of herself.

“Does he know that?” Bow asked incredulously. Glimmer knew that although Bow had many siblings, his relationships with them were tamer.

“Of course, he does!” She huffed. “Now are you ready to go to the lake or not?”

“Yes, great warrior. Please protect us on our quest.” Glimmer intoned dramatically. It made Adora crack a smile, but she kept walking.

Prince Catra hadn't visited in so long Glimmer could hardly remember the last time she’d seen her friend. She was excited about the visit. Catra was one of the few royals who not only tolerated Bow but accepted him as an equal. It helped that Halfmoon had a less rigid social structure, still in flux given their recent move to the surface.

Prince Catra walked in her Halfmoon garb, the material rich but the cut of the outfit sleek and minimalistic. Glimmer heard Adora take in a sharp breath. She didn't bother looking at her friend and instead curtsied in time with the prince's bow, her tail dipping to the side as she bent over. When she looked up to greet Glimmer her eyes strayed to the side and her mouth hung open for a moment, her ears swiveling away from Glimmer and instead facing Adora.

Glimmer turned and saw something she'd never seen before. Instead of the clear readiness that Adora always sported, her guard was blushing. And the usually unflappable prince almost tripped over her own feet, grabbing her tail with both hands to keep it from jerking.

"You have new security?" Catra asked Glimmer but her eyes never left Adora.

"Yes, Adora has been my guard for over a year now." She said cautiously still staring between the two, unclear what was happening.

Adora completely broke protocol, letting out a squeaky, "Hello, your majesty!" She turned an even deeper shade of red when she

realized what she did.

But nothing could prepare the group for how the prince flushed in return, and then a stuttering purr rolled from deep in her. Her eyes widen and she looked around as if looking for some other purring magicat, before forcing it down by clearing her throat.

It was of no use. When her eyes came back onto Adora staring softly at her, the purr roared back to life.

Well.

It would be an eventful visit it seems.

"Do you ever feel like we're an old married couple chaperoning a pair of hormonal teens?" Glimmer asked Bow as they walk arm in arm trailing behind Adora and Catra.

He sighed and gave her a long-suffering look. "All the time, Glimmer."

When they are far enough from the castle, they walk holding hands, pressing the occasional kiss to each other's face or lips. The stolen kisses feel better in the sunlight, less like a secret and more like devotion.

Ahead of them, Adora was holding the prince's arm, a blush never leaving her face. Catra had insisted that as a foreign dignitary, she should be closest to the guard for safety reasons. Never mind that the Halfmoon Prince didn't even travel with her own guard half the time. This was Catra’s third visit in as many months and the prince and Glimmer’s friend only seemed to be getting closer each time she returned.

"I really think I should be behind—" Adora looked regretful as she tried to take her hand back to move behind them as protocol required.

Catra cut in smoothly, "Nonsense, I'm sure Princess Glimmer and Bow think this is fine. What do you both say?" She gave them a beseeching look.

"I'm fine with how things are." Glimmer said trying to hide her smile. Seeing Ms. By-the-book-Adora breaking an unspeakable amount of protocol just to be near the prince was just too fun to pass up. She was happy for her friend who seemed to be happier than Glimmer had ever seen her. Catra gave Adora triumphant look, once again securing her hand as she tugged Adora along.

"It's cute." Glimmer whispered to Bow conspiratorially. She bumped his shoulder, and he took the hint to wrap his arm around her. She never felt warmer than in Bow’s arms.

Bow nodded his head, something clouding his expression. "It is." He agreed readily. "But how long will this last?"

She stared at the two ahead, noticing how Catra's tail brushed on Adora's shoulder, making the blonde turn to look away. When Adora was distracted, the prince interlaced their fingers, acting like they'd been holding hands since the beginning of the walk. Adora looked down at their joined hands in awe, a slight smile on her lips as she squeezed the magicat's fingers.

"I don't know." She whispered unsurely. The worry settled in her gut like a stone. She only wanted Adora to find happiness, she didn’t want the prince to break her heart. “It’s a difficult situation isn’t it?”

Bow gave her a sad smile. “We would know, wouldn’t we?”

She sighed, feeling some of her happiness escaping her lungs, as it did every time, she thought of the precarious position their relationship was in. “Yes, love.” She acknowledged. She wasn’t sure how it could be any different for Adora and Catra.

"The Prince of Halfmoon is visiting again today," Glimmer informed Adora, who was standing guard at her door as the

princess read for leisure.

Glimmer noted the dopey look that crossed Adora’s face immediately, her usually taut military posture relaxing slightly as she sighed. "Again, so soon?" She asked, tilting her head curiously.

"Yes. Seems *something* keeps bringing her back to Bright Moon." She raised an eyebrow as she stared Adora down.

Adora didn’t notice, her face flushed as she looked out the window with a faraway look in her eyes. "If only." She muttered softly. Adora turned to look at Glimmer, her head tilting at the expression on her face. "You seem to have opinions." She said, slowly noting the discontent on Glimmer's face.

She sighed, sitting next to Adora. "I just don’t want to see you in pain. I'm worried." She said honestly, placing a hand on her guard's shoulder.

"What about?" She asked with a furrowed brow.

"You and Catra. There's so much tension there and you've been out together on your day off before." She explained as Adora flushed red. "Catra has a kingdom to rule and I'm worried about the interest she's obviously taken in you."

"Interest?" Adora’s voice climbed in pitch.

Glimmer outright glared at her friend. "Adora, you have to be willfully ignorant to not see the way Catra stares at you."

Adora bit her lip. “She might have said something last time.” She offered hesitantly. “That she sees a future with me.” The words are whispered as if Adora feared saying them would make them ring false.

Glimmer’s face softened at that. She reached out and gripped Adora’s shoulder. “If that’s what your heart desires, Adora, then I wish it for you. But you’ve seen how difficult it has been for Bow

and I. I don’t want circumstances to be such that you both end up hurt.”

Adora nodded. “I understand. I’m not blind to the difference in our station. How could I be? But Catra—” Adora swallowed thickly. “I feel more like myself when I’m with her than I ever have. I think I’m in love with her, Glimmer.”

“Then I hope it’s for the best.” She swallowed down the concern and allowed herself to be happy for her friend. “Now, what if we have you change into something else before the prince gets here?”

Adora smiled brightly in gratitude and nodded her head.

Glimmer was always struck by how regal Angella looked with a teapot in her hand. She poured out their drinks and settled back into her chair across from Glimmer.

"So Catra has been visiting quite often," Angella noted, something loaded in her tone that Glimmer couldn't identify. Did her mother suspect what was happening between the foreign prince and her royal guard?

"Yeah, it's been nice." Glimmer says diplomatically. “You know Catra and I have always gotten along.”

"Nice." Angella echoed with a raised eyebrow. The silence remained stilted as Angella seemed to be trying to tell Glimmer something without words.

"Is there something you want to ask?" She finally asked, setting down her teacup.

"Is there a reason for her sudden trips to Bright Moon? It doesn't seem like it has much to do with business, we've already settled any pending discussions with Halfmoon."

"I don't know. It's good for the kingdoms, right?" Glimmer suggested. She wasn’t sure what tales Catra was spinning to take her leave to Bright Moon as often as she did.

"Yes. I'm just noting that you've grown rather close." She bit her lip, looking at Glimmer with wide eyes. "More than friends maybe?" She suggested.

"No! She's here for Adora." Glimmer spit out as a knee-jerk reaction.

Angella’s head snapped up. "Adora?"

Glimmer winced at how she lost her composure. "Yes. They're in love." She supplied, hoping her suspicions of Catra would not become an issue later on.

"Adora." She muttered under her breath, a quiet mumble as she furrowed her brow. As if she were lesser.

"Well don't say it like that!" She defended her friend.

Angella held a hand to her chest, eyes widening. "No, no! Adora is a fine woman, I'm just surprised. I've never seen her speak to a low-level dignitary, never mind higher royalty." She explained.

"Yeah, I don't know how Catra managed it, to be frank." She furrowed her brow as she stared at her mother, her long lilac hair falling around her like a curtain. "Why would you think Catra is here for me? You know how I feel about Bow."

The queen grimaces. "Bow is a lovely man; I didn’t mean it as a slight against him. But I love you most and I know it would be easier for you if your heart lied with someone like the Prince of Halfmoon." She explained, her face pure heartbreak "I didn't mean to imply anything else about your feelings."

"Bow is my love. I won’t ever take another.” She declares. "And the day Catra and I have more than friendship is the day hell

freezes over." She couldn't imagine a world in which she'd marry the prince.

She loved when she spent moments alone with Bow because they were so few and far between. With Adora's help, they managed to go out into the market, disguised as townsfolks. She knew that it was only the illusion of privacy—Adora was always a fair distance behind, inconspicuous, and ready to protect them at any moment. But she treasured those moments tightly and loved her friend for gifting them to her.

They were holding hands and although Glimmer had to have a hood covering her lilac hair, it was the most normal she felt in ages. "What do you think of this?" Bow asked her quietly as they passed by one of the jewelers.

She looked at the necklace he pointed out. It was a teardrop pearl necklace, one that reminded her of the earrings her mother wore. "It's beautiful." She noted, looking down at the gold chain with a smile.

Bow smiled brightly, eyes shining with love as he gestured for the merchant to sell him the necklace. He then turned to Glimmer with stars in his eyes. "I know I can't give you a betrothal present. But you are my partner in all the ways that matter, Glimmer. Would you accept this as a token of my affection?" He held out the necklace to her.

She could feel the tears welling up in her eyes. "Yes, Bow of course." She turned so he could put the necklace on her, but he grabbed her shoulder.

His eyes were sad as he gave her a soft smile. "We can't pull down your hood." He explained gently as he put the necklace away into his bag. "I'll help you with it once it's safe."

She dimmed momentarily at the reminder, not only that they weren't safe in public as themselves, but that their love wasn't

really safe anywhere. But then she looked at him, an unruly lock falling out of place as he shifted the things in his bag, and she knew that even this secret relationship with Bow was better than any public relationship with anyone else. Nothing could compare.

She grabbed his hand and pulled him close. "Do you want to take the back way to the castle when we finish browsing?" She whispered into his ear.

His eyes darkened and a slow smile flickered across his face. "That isn't the preplanned route." He pointed out.

Glimmer shrugged with a grin. "Adora will know when she sees us take it." It was right by *their* spot, one of the only secure places where they didn't need to be watched on the castle property. If they had a free afternoon, they'd often make the time to go there and lounge together. Other times they would end up rolling in the grass breathless with laughs or kisses, depending on the mood.

He laughed a joyful sound she tucked away into her heart. "She won't be happy."

"She'll live." Glimmer said with a roll of her eyes. She knew that Adora wouldn't *really* mind, and she'd enjoy the opportunity to provide a lecture on security. "Let's go get some street food, love?" Glimmer suggested.

"Sounds like a plan." Bow offered his arm and they made their way down the main street of the market.

It would be the last time they'd have a free day like this with Adora watching their back.

Catra was visiting once again, except instead of heading straight to Adora as she usually did, she was pacing in front of Glimmer's study. She eyed the magicat wearily, noting how her tail flickered and jerked. She refused to make eye contact with Glimmer, just taking deep breaths. Gimmer was about to interrupt her pacing when she stopped moving altogether.

"I'm going to do it," Catra said the abrupt sentence with a resolution that made Glimmer pause.

"What?" Glimmer tilted her head in concern. She had no idea what this was all about but she could feel her gut tightening at Catra’s distress.

Her tail thumped loudly against Glimmer’s bookshelf. "Propose to Adora," Catra explained. The prince almost bounced on her toes as she said the words.

Glimmer stared with her lips parted in surprise. "Have you spoken to Queen C'yra about this?" She couldn’t imagine the queen would take kindly to Adora

"Yes, I let her know so she could prepare." She muttered distractedly, her ears pinned back. "In case Adora says yes. You do think she would say yes?" She asked Glimmer.

But Glimmer was busy realizing the implication of Catra’s last words. "You're planning on taking her with you when you leave this trip." She breathed out slowly.

Catra nodded, as if it were obvious that her best friend would be gone within a few days. "Yes. That's what I wanted to talk to you about. I don't want to cause an international scandal. I was hoping to have your blessing and help to find the best way forward."

"I'm not Adora’s mother I can't speak for her." She rebuffed.

Catra pursed her lips, a fang poking out. "No, but you are her liege and her duty. You know how Adora is—if she feels like you need her here, she won't leave." Her eyes are pleading, vulnerable in a way she'd never seen the prince. "You also know Bright Moon better than me. I've consulted with one of my advisors at Halfmoon, but he was hesitant to predict how the queen and her council might see this." She reached out and put a hand on Glimmer’s shoulder. "I need your help, Glimmer." She finished softly.

Glimmer remained unmoved. "What are your intentions with Adora?" She asked point blank.

Catra eyed her warily. "I thought you weren't her mother." She pointed out quickly.

"I'm not.” She admitted readily. “But I am her liege as you pointed out. More importantly her friend. I want to make sure." Even if Adora desired it, she wouldn't help Catra unless she knew the prince was planning on doing right by her friend.

"I love her. I know it might seem silly, but from the moment I saw her I just knew there would be no going back for me." She admitted shyly. Her tail wrapped around her own leg. "She loves me too. But I can't keep coming to Bright Moon this frequently to see her when I have duties at home.” She explained. “I could lie and tell you that's the reason I want to marry Adora now, but honestly? Every day without Adora as my wife feels wasted."

"You see forever with her?" Glimmer clarified.

"And longer than that." Catra supplied, her ears pinned back, no doubt embarrassed by her love confession.

"Okay, I'll help you." Glimmer decided with a nod. She winced as she delivered the next bit of news. "I *might* have already told my mother that you've been courting."

Catra’s tail slashed violently at the news and she reached behind her to still it. "What did she say? Did you tell Adora?" She demanded, her voice pitching up.

Glimmer waved her hands about. "No! Look I know I should have asked first but she thought you were here for *me*! I didn't have a choice! There isn’t exactly any other explanation I could come up with on the spot!" She defended.

"That's ridiculous! You love Bow. Why would I be courting you?" She pointed out.

She sighed to cover the twinge in her heart. "Bow and I can't marry." She said flatly.

Catra looked at her like she'd grown two heads. "... whyever not?"

"The council forbids it." She sighed, a heavy thing that wracked her body.

"What did he do that it's banned?" Catra asked, baffled by the idea. "He's just—he's so good! You'd have to be blind to not see how that man loves you."

Glimmer presses her lips together, her fingers twitching at her side. "I know. But I can only marry someone of royal lineage."

"But that's—they'll keep you from him? Your mother can't just decree that you can?" Catra pressed, outrage clear in her voice.

Glimmer turned away taking a few steps toward her desk. "I don't want to discuss the matter further."

There's a stilted silence for a moment. "Forgive me. That must be so painful. I was just surprised." The look on her face is more disgusted than surprised. Glimmer can't blame her— she's disgusted by the council too.

She changes the subject, not wanting to dwell. "Are you taking Adam as well?"

Catra's eyes widen in surprise as she puts a hand to her face. "I wasn't planning to. I hadn't really thought of him." She admitted. "Halfmoon will always be open to Adora's brother but I'm not sure if it's what he wants, to be taken from everything he built just because his sister married." At the last word, she wore a soft smile.

Glimmer could already tell the two were going to be revolting if they managed to become betrothed. "Yeah, I think it would be best if he stayed for the time being. It'll be more palatable to lose one member of the royal guard than two." She added.

Catra looked at her with a bit of disbelief. “So, you’re really going to help me do this?” She echoed again.

Glimmer smiled wide, nodding. “I want what’s best for Adora and you make her happy.”

Catra broke protocol, enveloping her into a hug, her tail coming around her waist. “Thank you so much, sparkles.” She whispered.

She held Catra just as tightly. “You’re welcome. Just make sure to take care of Adora, alright?”

Catra is solemn as she said, “always.”

Within three days’ time, Adora was betrothed and moving to a new kingdom, leaving all her former loyalties behind. Glimmer knew that Adora would be happier with her love but a part of her ached to know that she would very rarely see her dear friend.

“What is your book about, love?” Bow asked as he sat down bringing Glimmer a cup of tea and a tray with sweets. She looks over, pressing a soft kiss to his cheek. Since Adora moved to Halfmoon they had to be more careful but her study was always a private space they could enjoy together.

“It’s a fictional story about She-ra.” She explained as she rested her book on the table. Her favorite part of the study is the amount of natural light that flooded the room during the day, perfect for relaxing.

Bow rolled his eyes. “Did dad convince you that She-ra would come back?”

“Well, he was my tutor for most of my life, same as you Bow. I heard all of the stories.” Most believed that She-ra was a true warrior of Etheria, but some doubted the prophecy that she would return again, especially as the war with the Horde raged on.

“Do you think she’d ever come back? With everything happening?” He asked hesitantly.

Her eyes grow sad as she thinks of her father. She still missed him dearly, never quite recovering from losing that piece of her heart. And her mother was worse than she was.

“I don’t know. But I’d love to think so.” Glimmer whispered. The idea that a magical warrior could just show up and make their lives easier was an appealing one. Bright Moon was not in any real danger but that didn’t mean the Horde was any less of a threat.

“It’ll work out Glimmer, you’ll see.” Bow insisted. He gave her a soft kiss before tugging on her arm. “Let’s cuddle on the chaise while your tea cools.” He suggested, a certain light in his eye that tugged at Glimmer’s gut.

The tea was dead cold by the time Glimmer returned to her book.

“Eloping, Adora. We are *eloping*.” Catra insisted. “This is all ridiculous anyway! Just pomp! No substance.” Catra’s tail jerked in annoyance as she stood tall. Glimmer noted the fire in her eyes, and she had no doubt that the magicat meant it when she said it.

Adora simply rolled her eyes. “It’s the third time this week she’s decided on eloping,” Adora whispered conspiratorially to her friend. Glimmer tried to stifle her giggle. It was so good to see her again after all these months apart.

“I heard that Adora.” She flickered her ears at the blonde. “Did you forget you’re marrying a magicat?”

Adora beamed and stood in front of Catra. “How could I possibly forget, dearest?” She bent down and places soft kisses on both of Catra’s ears and the magicat turned an interesting shade of red. “I just think that it might be prudent to wait given that the whole kingdom is expecting our nuptials in a few months.”

Catra leaned forward pulling her betrothed into a hug. “But I want to marry you *now*.” She said petulantly.

Adora laughed her eyes only for Catra. “I do too.” She assured.

Glimmer watched her friends in silent awe. She was still amazed by how open they could be about their love now that they were betrothed, about how settled in they seemed to be with each other.

Catra was the first to remember they aren’t quite alone, her ears pinning back as she caught Glimmer’s gaze. “Sorry, Glimmer.”

She waved them off. “Nonsense, it’s great to see you so at peace here, Adora.”

She once again donned that dopey grin. “I’m beyond happy here in Halfmoon.” Her eyes tighten a fraction. “I do miss you all. How are Adam and Bow?"

“They are well. Couldn’t make the trip for obvious reasons.” She rarely was allowed to travel with Bow and Adam had his duty at the capital.

“Please send them all my love.” Adora expressed her eyes shining with feeling.

Catra wrapped an arm around her betrothed. “After we are married, we will be able to travel to Bright Moon,” Catra assured lowly. She then tossed a cheeky grin Adora’s way. “Which is why we should *elope*.”

Adora gave her an indulgent sigh and although Glimmer loved them both, she was right in thinking that they are disgustingly in love.

"You're going to be a princess." She teased her longtime friend. Adora looked gorgeous in her wedding dress, her hair artfully styled and her jewelry on.

She started to blush. "The prince's consort." She corrected gently. "Although if Catra ascends to the throne I'll be queen." She conceded.

"Everyone will still call you princess, you know." It was thrilling in way. For the class barriers between them to fall away, equals not only in private but everywhere they go now.

"Yeah, but I can't let all the princess lessons go to waste." She chided.

Glimmer gently primped one of Adora's loose hairs until it was sitting where it was meant to. "Are you nervous?"

"A little. What if I fall Glimmer? There are so many people out there." She whispered in a panic.

"Adora you're a trained soldier. You'll be fine." She rolled her eyes. "Besides, I wasn't asking about that. You know, marriage."

"Oh! I mean it's a lot of responsibility. Being in charge of ruling feels way out of my wheelhouse." She laughed nervously. "But *Catra*. She's my other half." The smile that bloomed on her face could only be that of a woman in love. "There's nothing I wouldn't be so I could be hers. And I can't wait until I can get out of this dress and start my life with her."

"That excited for the wedding night?" Glimmer teased.

Adora turns redder than the rubies in her tiara. "Glimmer!"

"What? It's normal." She dismissed. "Have you two... *discussed* it?"

Adora shot her an uncertain look. "Do you mean if we...?" Glimmer nodded. Adora winced. "We haven't."

Glimmer blinked at her friend. "Oh. I'm surprised Catra is keeping to that tradition."

She smiled awkwardly. "It was me. I mean, we haven't been waiting for all that long and I want to start our marriage off on the right foot."

"Anything you want to know?"

She shook her head. "No, Catra and I haven't made love, but we've both been with others."

Glimmer smirked. "Really Adora! I didn't know."

"Well, it wasn't appropriate you were my regent." She pointed out, her face taking on the same stern look she got when speaking of decorum and propriety.

"You've probably seen more of Bow than anyone but me." She pointed out.

Adora laughed at that. "I was your guard. But now that I'm not, I will say I'll be glad to not have to ferry Bow to safety in a half-naked state when Queen Angella gets it in her head to visit you unannounced."

"You ready then? Want me to call Adam for you?" She smiled widely.

"Yes. Thank you for everything, Glimmer." The warm look in Adora's eyes told her it was about more than keeping her company as she got ready.

"Think nothing of it." She waved off, holding out her arm and guiding her through the hallway.

When Catra and Adora exchanged vows, she felt iridescently happy for her friends. She wished she could share the moment with Bow. Her eyes caught his in another section far from where the foreign dignitaries sat. He sent her a bright but discrete smile.

She so wished she could marry him.

She felt numb for the last few days, still not sure how this happened. No one knew where Queen Adora had disappeared to and given that she was gone for close to a week now, there was little hope they would find her again. Glimmer still had duties in Bright Moon but she'd arranged for a diplomatic trip to Halfmoon as soon as it was prudent.

She heard a knock at her door, which was very unusual this late at night. When she opened the door, it was Adam standing there, his usual joyful demeanor nowhere to be found.

"Adam." His name sounded like an apology and his face crumpled at the sound of it.

"I know you're going to Halfmoon. I want to leave to go as well." His words were measured but he plead with his eyes, a man worried about his sister.

"Of course. I'm going in a few days with Bow. You're more than welcome to have leave and to come with us." She wanted to mention that the queen had tried to force him to take leave when Adora disappeared, and he outright refused. She bit her tongue, sure it wouldn't be productive to bring it up now. "Whatever you need okay Adam?"

He bowed, his eyes tight. "Thank you, your majesty." He left without another word, his gait perfectly even, to the point of being robotic.

Glimmer stared after him—that man was going to fall apart sooner or later. She ran a tired hand over her face, rubbing the sleep out of her eyes. The moment she reached her bed she collapsed on it, crying. It was slowly sinking in that Adora was no longer with them, probably kidnapped by the Horde just like her father was.

She felt a warm hand at her back and turned to look at Bow, his own tears streaming. She pulled him close and cried harder. It felt like Bow's presence gave her permission to fall apart the way she'd wanted to for the last few days.

As her sobs quiet, Glimmer’s eyes were swollen shut, the lids stretched and uncomfortable. Bow’s tears had dried at some point, and he just held her, rubbing her back.

“A part of me always felt jealous of them you know?” They were able to get married and love each other publicly. We don’t have that option.” Glimmer admitted. “But now—I can't believe she just disappeared like that."

"I know. Glim. Me neither." He took a deep breath, his chest moving under Glimmer’s head. “I felt jealous too. I think it’s normal, you shouldn’t feel guilty.”

“Poor Catra.” She whispered. “Poor Adora.” The more she thought about it, the more those two sentiments just circled each other.

Bow held her tighter. “Maybe they’ll find her.” He whispered the hope, but it feels like a false one.

Catra was a shell of a person. Even that was a generous characterization. She looked aged, bent over the books in her study, eyes dimmed as she perused the parchment in front of her.

"Hi, Catra." She called softly. She was surprised that Catra even allowed her in. It had been three months since Adora's disappearance and few people had seen the King. On their first visit, only Adam had been allowed to go see the magicat.

"Glimmer. Bow." She gave them a tired smile that didn't reach her eyes. "How are you both?"

"Upset," Bow replied honestly, walking closer and crouching by Catra's seat. “We would have come sooner if we thought it would help." He didn’t mention that they tried but she turned them away.

Catra's laugh was short and a little manic. "Nothing helps Bow."

She reached out and put a hand on Catra's shoulder. "Look, I know that you're hurting right now—"

"Glimmer." She said calmly. "You cannot *fucking* imagine it." The words were harsh but what hurt Glimmer was the heartbreak behind them.

"I know Catra. I'm not pretending to." She whispered softly.

"She's still out there somewhere," Catra said stubbornly as her eye filled with tears. "Adora wouldn't leave me like this."

Glimmer eyed her uncertainly. "I don't mean to suggest Adora would leave you willingly."

"She's alive. I'd know it Glimmer. I *know* I'd know it, if she weren't." She was sobbing openly now, and Glimmer wrapped her arms around shaking shoulders. "I feel so empty without her here. How am I supposed to do this on my own?" She shoved the papers she was working with to the side.

She looked up at Bow, her own light in the dark, and stayed speechless. She didn't think she could go on without him either. They pulled her into a group hug, holding the shattered edges together.

"Our decision is final, your majesty. There are no circumstances where we would allow a union between the princess and the master archer. He is not of royal lineage and if not for his—*friendship*—with the princess would likely not be an advisor." Norwyn said stiffly.

Glimmer's hand clenched under the table, and she refused to look at Bow. If she looked at him and saw how that sentiment hurt him she'd simply have to fly across the table and commit bodily harm against that sniveling Bright Moon councilmember.

"Meeting adjourned."

The councilmembers quickly disassembled, some shooting apologetic glances her way. She didn’t want their apologies. They had the power to change the law and didn’t for one reason or another. Only Bow and her mother stayed. Queen Angella opened her mouth, probably to give Glimmer the same old tired excuses she always did.

She held out her hand. "Adora disappeared over six months ago. I know what's important and it's what I share with Bow." She eyed her desperately, "I want to marry him, mom."

"You heard the same thing as me dear. I’m sorry. I’ll keep them from pushing you into a union, but I don’t have the authority to change the law. You know this.”

It didn’t matter how many different ways it was said to her, no matter what, it always felt like a dagger in her gut. Bow reached out and gripped her hand. She turned to look at him, and he looked at her with those sad defeated eyes she knew well.

Her shoulders slumped. “I understand.” She understood, but she wasn’t sure that she would ever forgive.

Her stomach was heavy as she walked into the library where she knew Bow was waiting for her. She'd sworn time again that she’d never let it come to this. That she married him or no one. What would he think of her?

Bow was reading a book. When she came in, he looked up, and the moment he saw her he smiled brightly. He walked over and after looking around to ensure they were alone, pulled her into his arms. He'd been increasingly affectionate since the attack on Bright Moon.

"Hey, lovely. How are you feeling today? Were you happy with the relief package from Halfmoon?" He’d been by her side since the attack on Bright Moon, there to help her shoulder any burden, big or small. He was her true partner in every sense of the word.

"Bow. We need to talk." She took a deep breath, willing the words to come out. “Catra proposed a union between Halfmoon and Bright Moon.”

He looked over at her with a curious look on his face. "She wants to marry you?"

"No—not want. She needs to marry *someone*, and she thought that I made the most sense." She explained nervously.

"Made sense." His voice was an echo. "What did she say when you told her no?" She stared at Bow unable to speak. He took a step towards her. "Glimmer." He said slowly. "What did she say?"

"I haven't said no." Glimmer starts cautiously. "I wouldn’t say yes without talking to you first." She assured quickly.

Bow’s eyes widen, looking as if someone hit him. "You—you want to say yes?"

The disbelief in the air was palpable.

She sighed. "Bow, you have to understand that—"

"Understand. *Understand*? Glimmer, what is there to understand?" Bow was rarely angry, but his eyes flashed indignantly now, fists clenched to his side.

"It would be a pretense. Just a pretense you know my heart belongs to you." What Catra was offering her—power and a way to end the war—it was something that she needed, not what she wanted.

"You'd be Catra's *wife*. That isn't a pretense, Glimmer, you would be *married*." He spat out, voice shaking.

"If you tell me not to do it, I won’t." She said looking up at his face. She would do many things for her duty, but she couldn't find it in herself to lose Bow.

Bow groaned running a hand through his dark hair. "Why are you putting me in this position?" He sat back down clutching his head.

"I'm not trying to Bow! But look at the palace! Look out there!" She pointed out to the destruction on the streets, the mess that was her capital. "I can't sit by and do nothing. I don't want to do that. You *know* that. But it isn't about me."

He stood quietly, biting his lip. "Glimmer, if you think this is what's best for Bright Moon, what kind of man would I be if I stood in your way?" He looks pained but resigned. "I've never asked you to put me before Bright Moon and I won't start now."

"Bow, you know this wouldn't change things between us. I still love you. You'd come to Halfmoon with me." She explained. She knew that Catra held no aspiration of romance, her friend had given up on love long ago.

"I know we won't *want* this to change things between us Glimmer. But can you really tell me that you know for certain?" He said quietly.

She reached out and grabbed both of his hands in hers. "I know for certain there's nothing I wouldn't do to keep your love, to keep you safe. I'm asking you to trust me."

He gave her a weak smile. "I'll always love and trust you, Glimmer." He pulled her in for another hug this one more desperate than the first. She ignored the tears she felt slip on her shoulder, and he ignored the way she stiffened when she felt them.

Halfmoon was both freer and more constraining than Bright Moon. She had Bow in her bed every night, not just the odd day that he could sneak into her room, or she could sneak into his.

But the bulk of her days were spent with Catra, in meetings or making decisions, and then posing as a couple at other times. It felt strange to feel Catra wrap a casual arm around her or hold

out her arm so they could walk together. Nothing more than that level of affection was expected thankfully, but even those small touches left her feeling unsettled.

She'd gotten to their room and was stripping out of her dress when Bow walked in looking haggard. She walked up to him cupping his face in her hand. "What's wrong, love?" She asked him softly.

He leaned his head against Glimmer’s, bending down to be closer to her. "Nothing. Just tired."

"Want to tell me about your day?" She offered hopefully.

"Yeah." He gives her a soft smile. "I was at the school today. I taught kids about archery and Bright Moon customs." Glimmer nodded along. Angella and Catra agreed that Bow would have some duties to excuse his leaving Bright Moon, no matter how thin the excuse was. His face turned soft as he thought about it. "The kits are beautiful and inquisitive. They really are such wonderful children." His eyes turn unbearably sad. "And then I thought—you'll probably have this with Catra right?" His whisper held no judgment or rage just a quiet longing that broke her heart in two.

She whipped around to look at him. "No Bow, we aren't having children together, we are just stopping the war." They hadn't talked about it specifically but she was sure Catra didn't want that with her. Really with anyone that wasn't Adora, but that was the cross she bore every day with Adora gone.

"But wouldn't you have to? If the war drags on? You need heirs and Catra does too. At least publicly you'd be a family. And even if you didn't, and you somehow separate which seems difficult—you can never have that with me can you?"

"Bow we've never spoken of children."

He pressed his lips together. "But I've thought of them." He admitted in a whisper. "You'd make a wonderful mother. I'm not

sure that it would be the path for us if we were in a world of choice, but that isn't the world we live in anyways." He looked defeated, eyes sunken in. It made Glimmer wonder if he hadn't been sleeping at night and just never bothered to tell her.

She tugged Bow into her arms. "I don't know that I've ever thought about children besides the need for heirs." She admitted ruefully. "But I know that this isn't forever. We just have to hold faith, alright?"

"In what, a miracle?" He said with a small twitch of his lips.

"Or in Catra and I figuring out this mess." She offered.

He cupped her face in his hands. She felt so small and delicate as he looked at her lovingly. "You *are* my miracle, princess." He placed a soft kiss on her lips. They didn't speak much after that.

"I can't believe she's back!" The news of Adora's return was a balm on Glimmer's soul. She really hadn't held on to even the slightest hope that her friend was somehow alive.

Bow was all smiles as he pulled her into his lap. "I know. It's the best news we could have wished." He sighed. "I haven't seen Catra this happy in who knows how long. Adam too, for that matter."

"One more mind in our corner as we try to end this war. Never mind her newfound powers." She felt lighter than she has in so long, buoyed by the turn of the tide.

For a moment Bow looked sad. "She must have been so lonely with no one with her all this time. And it can't be easy, coming back and thinking your wife is marrying your friend." He looked up hesitantly at Glimmer as if worried about what she might say.

"I understand that this is different for you and Adora than it is for Catra and I." She filled the silence. "It's difficult for us too. And I'm so sorry that I'm hurting you."

“I’ll always forgive you, Glimmer.” He reminded her gently. “Well, I won’t forgive you if you steal my new arrow set again.” He teased with a smile.

“I was twelve at the time! You can’t hold that against me still.” She protested but she couldn’t keep the smile off her face as she did so.

“Maybe I need some recompense to be convinced to forgive you.” His dark eyes flashed and the atmosphere shifted between them, Glimmer taking a step closer until her arms were wrapped around his broad shoulders.

She skimmed her nose against his Adam’s apple, enjoying how it bobs as he swallows. “I’d be more than happy to provide for you, love.”

A few hours later, she laid her head on his chest and his strong heartbeat was the sound of her world. Nothing mattered in moments like this one. She wasn't heir to the Bright Moon and Halfmoon thrones, betrothed to a King, or a lead strategist in the war effort. She was a woman in love with the kindest man she knew.

"That was nice." She commented lazily, still feeling boneless.

"Hmm yeah." He agreed, his voice deeper than usual, almost rumbling with sleep.

With Bow wrapped around her and Adora back, it felt like maybe they finally had the upper hand.

"How was your time with Adora?" She asked idly as she looked up from a report. She was already packed for Salineas and the long travels ahead of her.

"Lovely. Even though she's a princess now too, it's just easy to relate to each other." His sigh was almost dreamy. "The two fools lucky enough to be handpicked by royalty." He teased.

"You're no fools. And I'd pick you anytime, anywhere." Glimmer gave Bow a resounding kiss.

“I know darling, I know.” He assured before looking down at her bag. An odd look crossed his face. “What’s all this?”

“We are leaving for Salineas soon. I thought you knew.”

He shook his head a frown marring his complexion. “I didn’t know you were leaving so soon.” He made to move toward their bedroom. “I haven’t packed yet.”

“Bow, you aren’t—you can’t come.” Glimmer explained slowly, watching as he freezes halfway to the door. “It’s Alliance business”

“Oh.” He said slowly. He purses his lips, arms crossed over his chest. "At least Adora has Shera. She doesn't have to be left behind every time you and Catra are going off to save the world together.” Bow sighed, looking at Glimmer with hollow eyes. "Go to Salineas. It's what you want. What you've always wanted."

"Bow it's not like that!"

"Then tell me what it's like Glimmer! I've always been your dirty little secret but at least in Bright Moon I didn't have to stomach the sight of you with someone else!" He finally exploded, letting out what had been festering in his heart since he first caught wind of the proposal. "At least in Bright Moon, you weren't anyone else's, even if you weren't mine."

"Bow I've always been yours." She insisted.

"It doesn't feel that way sometimes." He looked around the room. “I knew you’d always be Bright Moon’s first, but it feels like I’m lower on your priority list than ever before.” He was tired, his brown eyes sad as he looked around the room.

“Everything was fine just a minute ago!” She yelled frustrated.

Bow shook his head. “If you really think that Glimmer, you haven’t been paying attention.”

Her gut dropped to her toes as she watched Bow leave for their bedroom. She huffed, grabbing her bag and heading out the door. She couldn’t help what her duty demanded of her. Bow would understand.

Glimmer stewed for most of their travel time and the couple left her be for the most part. That is until she was left alone with Catra in their shared bedroom. In the long hour in the carriage, her indignation and anger slowly curdled into guilt until it burned a hole in her chest.

The King looked impatient, tail swinging lightly behind her as she climbed into bed, “Alright, out with it. I won’t be able to fall asleep with you looking so sullen.” She finally said.

"Bow was angry about the trip." Glimmer whispered. "He says we always leave him behind. He's right." That was the problem—it felt that with every corner they turned, it was harder and harder to fit Bow into her life. And what kind of life would it be anyway when the man she loved couldn’t be front and center in it?

Catra furrowed her brow, looking concerned. “I didn’t know he felt that way.”

“Well, how could he not? He’s holed up in Halfmoon, a place where he isn’t even really working.” She whispered.

“Glimmer.” Her arm softly patted Glimmer’s shoulder, preserving the space between them. “We can’t—there’s nothing for it really.” She informed hesitantly.

"I know there isn't a real solution I just hate that I'm hurting him."

"Maybe you need to spend some time with him. Quality time you know?" Catra suggested faintly. “He probably wouldn’t worry so

much about being left out if he felt that he had you close.”

Glimmer sighed. She had been terrible at balancing her duties and making time to spend with Bow. It’s time she did better. Her eyes cut to her friend. "You want everyone to think you’re a big bad king, but you’re just a softy." She accused.

"Don't tell the Horde now." She chuckles softly. "I don't care if you know. You're a good friend, Glimmer. I'm not glad we’re stuck in this mess of our own making, but I know that this could be so much worse.”

Glimmer nodded. “We’re one step closer. It’s a matter of resistance now.” They all had to hold on until they made it out of this. She fervently hoped that Adora really would find the salvation they’d been looking for.

It was like being brought right into the same spot, four years earlier. Everything had been going so well—Glimmer had managed to spend more time with Bow, and the Alliance was defeating the Horde at every turn—but then Catra was taken from them.

They’d been dealing with the fallout all day and by the time there was nothing left to be done, Glimmer’s feet were sore and her heart ached. She felt like she’d been through a hundred years in just this day.

"It feels like deja’vu, doesn't it?" Bow whispered into the stillness of their bedroom. They’d retired for the evening after making sure Adora found her own bed.

Glimmer sighed, her heart heavy. "I really wish it wasn't this memory." She lamented. Watching Adora’s vacant stare was like sitting with Catra when Adora was gone. Not to mention the own hole in her chest, now filled with worry for her friend.

"We could still get Catra back. I mean we got Adora back and that felt like a miracle." Bow suggested weakly.

It was a long shot. There were clear incentives to kill Catra quickly —to destabilize the nation that had rapidly become the rallying point of the Alliance.

"Let's not wait another few years before we get Catra back." She managed to mutter out.

"Of course not." Bow comforted, wrapping his arms around her.

She leaned into his touch and fell apart, crying until her breathing jags. "I just—why does this always happen when we get close? When we might have a chance to finish this? Why is it our friends?" Catra and Adora didn't deserve this. No one did.

Bow rubbed soothing circles on her back and she can feel his own hot tears landing on her cheek. "It's unfair. But we've made it this far, Glimmer. I know we can figure this out." He sniffled.

"I'd be lost without you, Bow. Sometimes it feels like you're the only thing that keeps me from falling apart." She admitted. "I don't know that I'd be strong enough to go on."

"You would. Because you're loyal to your people and you have an infallible sense of right and wrong. Because you're giving. It's what I love about you." He wiped the tears out of his eyes and brought her close for a kiss. "But if I can be here, that's where I want to be. No matter how grueling it is sometimes, the challenges we face."

Tomorrow. They would face all of the problems that stem from Catra's kidnapping and be strong for Adora and Adam. But tonight, Glimmer fell asleep, soft tears rolling down her face while she was comforted by the man she loved.

The last thing that Glimmer expected when Catra called her for a status update was for Bow to be there. They'd rescued Catra, successfully broken their engagement, and continued to put the Horde on their heels. Glimmer couldn't ask for more.

But when Catra explained that she'd provided a solution to a problem she'd deemed unsolvable—when she made Bow a duke of Halfmoon so that they could marry—Glimmer didn't know if she'd ever felt joy that pure.

She'd been pressed close to Bow—to her betrothed, soon to be *her husband*—until she caught sight of a regal woman. The moment she saw her mother, Glimmer ran to her, throwing her arms around her.

"You finally did it." She breathes out, feeling like a small child again as her mother holds her back fiercely. "You stood up to the council."

Angella scoffs, taking a step back to look at her. "Don't thank me, it was mostly Catra's plan She had to do the heavy lifting, as it were."

"No. Catra couldn't have done this without your blessing. You could have said no it would have been the easiest way."

"Sometimes the easiest way isn't the best way. That's something you taught me." Angella said softly, her face solemn. "I'm sorry it took me so long to find the courage to do what's right." She smiled easier now. "I'm happy for you and Bow. He will make a fine consort one day."

Even as excited as Glimmer was for her own wedding, it was beyond stressful to plan it, especially with the war efforts still underway. Adora smoothed out her veil, tossing it this way and that until it dropped perfectly on her head.

She shot her friend a furtive look. "When are you getting married huh?" Glimmer asked, to take her mind off her own nerves. She wanted to walk down the aisle and meet Bow there already.

"The moment we finish this war; I'm going to marry Catra again." She said confidently. Adora was wearing an Etherian army uniform for the wedding, and she looked commanding in it.

"What if the war takes too long." She challenged. Glimmer hadn't spoken about it at length with Catra, but she can tell the King is dying to wed her wife again. She thought the likely delay came from Adora.

Her eyes blazed a familiar glowing blue. "It won't." She assured lowly. "I'll move heaven and earth if I have to. And then I will take my rightful place, next to Catra."

"Who will be next to Catra?" The King herself called out. Adora was startled, a blush covering her cheeks and her eyes softening as she looks at Catra. "I won't be standing next to you for this one, dearest."

Adora rolled her eyes. "I know where I stand, Catra." She approached the brunette and placed a soft kiss on her ears. Glimmer noticed her tail wrapping around Adora's waist.

Catra shifted her gaze to Glimmer and her smile brightens even further. "You're a vision, Glimmer." She reached out and squeezed her shoulder, careful not to shift any of the painstakingly crafted outfit. "Bow is a very lucky man."

"Thank you. This is all thanks to you and your fast thinking." Glimmer didn't know if she'd ever be able to thank Catra enough for helping them this way.

"Anything for my former betrothed." She says with a theatrical bow. "I need to go. I have a wedding to officiate." She gave Adora a kiss before backing toward the door.

"I'm so glad Norwyn isn't officiating." He not so gracefully bowed out, saying he'd rather be dead than be forced to lead Glimmer and Bow in their union.

"I don't know, I'm interested to think what shade of purple he would be if he had to do it." Catra had taken great pleasure in the play-by-play Glimmer gave of the old council member throwing a fit when he realized Glimmer would finally be allowed to marry Bow. "See you two soon."

Adora was still staring at the door, biting her lip. “I’m going to marry her again.” She muttered under her breath.

Glimmer smiled, wondering if perhaps Adora wasn’t as patient as she let on.

She almost cried as she walked down the aisle. Her wedding was as huge and lavish as that of any princess, but the fact that Bow was finally the one waiting for her made it feel like so much more.

The moment she caught his stare, everything else just fell away, leaving only her and him. He looks awestruck, his eyes never move from her from the moment the doors opened and she was led inside by her mother.

A few steps from Bow, Angella stops to turn to her. "I'm so happy for you love. Your father would be proud." She places a soft kiss on her cheek and then turns to hug Bow before joining their hands.

She gave her mother a tearful look before looking at her husband-to-be. She took a few steps forward and she was now standing in front of him, both hands intertwined as they stared at each other.

"Glimmer." His voice choked and his eyes filled with tears. "You are so beautiful."

She took a shuddering breath and really looked at Bow. He looked every bit a prince, dressed in the standard Bright Moon colors, but with detailing from Halfmoon, given his new status there.

Before Catra began she beckoned them closer. She whispered to them, putting on hand on each other their shoulders. "Given circumstances, I won't be able to be as candid as I'd like in the vows." She whispered. Glimmer could hear confusion from the swell of attendants at their back. "I'm in awe of the love you two have for each other. I always have been. I've no doubt that you will be well suited for this union because you've been each other's since you were children. Your love has stood the test of time and

heartbreak, and it will continue to withstand so much more." Catra eyed the couple with a bright smile. "Ready to proceed with the ceremony?"

"Born ready," Bow said as he looked at Glimmer.

She tightened her grip on his hand. "Of course." Glimmer had waited her whole life for this union—it was a dream to be there in the moment, holding Bow's hand as they looked into each other's eyes and exchanged lifelong promises they'd made years ago in their hearts.

Bow was settled by the fire in their ante chamber, sipping on a hot mug of tea while reading. He looked cozy and warm, and all Glimmer wanted was to sit at his side and soak in this relaxed atmosphere so she could hold it in her mind forever.

"Do you ever miss it?" She blurted out.

He looked up, unbothered by the interruption as he smiled at his Queen. He didn't look as young as he once did, their wedding more a far memory than a recent event.

"Miss what?" He asked as he closed his book and set his mug down.

He pats the couch right next to himself motioning for her to sit. She forwent the suggestion and sat down on his lap.

"Sneaking in and out of my bed." She shot her husband a sultry look.

He laughed heartily gripping her close as he pressed a kiss to her lips. By the time he finished kissing her, she forgot what her question was.

"No," he finally settled on. He eyed her smugly as he noticed her heaving breaths. His eyes softened and he pressed close to her,

placing a chaste kiss on her forehead. "Nothing's better than being yours and letting the whole world know it."

She felt warm as she leaned her head forward, resting it against his shoulder.

"I was always yours." She assured softly. Sometimes the hurts from having to hide their love still ached, but at this moment, it felt like no scar at all.

"I know. I was yours too." He replied easily, holding her tenderly for one endless moment.

End Notes

This has been in the works for what feels like literal ages. It was so fun to revisit this universe. I hope you all like it!

Kudos and comments are the best. You can find me on Twitter and Tumblr.

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!